

Photographs: PTI

CENTRE STAGE CM Stalin and son and deputy Udhayanidhi (extreme right) at a DMK Foundation Day ceremony in Chennai, Sep. 15

The DMK chief has set an ambitious target for the party rank and file—winning 200 of the 234 seats in the legislative assembly (they now have 133 seats, with alliance partners 159). The work has already started; early in October, the DMK appointed external observers for all 234 constituencies. Party general secretary Duraimurugan says the observers, other than focusing on booth committees and booth level agents, will report to the top party leadership on constituency developments and also identify potential winning candidates.

As for its governance record, the Stalin government is adding more social sector programmes to improve the party's public persona. In 2026, the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance—which includes the Congress and 12 other parties—will encounter anti-incumbency as well as the challenge by rival parties, including megastar Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), which hopes to offer a younger, more vibrant alternative (see box *The New Poll Star*). "The DMK government's performance has been average, but it has had some successful programmes and initiatives. There is no visible infighting within the party, but there will be realignments with Udhayanidhi's emergence," says political analyst Ramu Manivannan.

For three decades now, the DMK's rainbow coalition has got on board smaller caste and community cohorts that add to its critical mass during polling. This initiative in consolidation has enabled it to better its vote share significantly in recent elections, especially after rival AIADMK supremo Jayalalithaa's passing.

Still, there are challenges aplenty. Anti-incumbency, particularly in matters of law and order, is a traditional bugbear for the DMK whenever in power. The anti-DMK social media, split as they may be in political terms after the AIADMK and BJP parted ways, has been consistent in taking the ruling party to task. In comparison, the DMK's social media machinery has been inefficient, whether in defending the party or promoting the government's agenda and initiatives. "The DMK's advantage is that the AIADMK-BJP combine, which did respectably in 2021, is hopelessly split and squabbling and the cadre are demoralised," explains political commentator N. Sathiya Moorthy.

FUTURE READY

- **CM Stalin is 71, needs to win a second term at any cost. Also needs to secure the future of son and deputy CM Udhayanidhi**
- **Party revamp on, external observers in all 234 constituencies to identify candidates with potential**
- **Slew of female-centric programmes launched to keep women voters happy**
- **Focus on more social sector projects to improve DMK govt's public persona**

A heartening fact for the DMK is that its allies are unlikely to drift to join hands with rivals. Some of them, especially Congress state president K. Selvaperunthangai and party MP Karthi Chidambaram, have been provoking the DMK but analysts feel they are doing it largely to try and get more seats for the party in the 2026 assembly polls. Similarly, the Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) had turned up the discordant volume, calling for prohibition and ending the access to illicit brew when Stalin was away to woo investments in the US. But on meeting the DMK chief after his return, VCK leader Thol Thirumavalavan declared that their alliance was in safe hands.

An area that the DMK is focusing on is addressing the increasing sense of "alienation in the post-Jallikattu generation" of Tamil youth, and steering them away from the BJP-led NDA and its anti-Dravidian Hindutva. This, while also allaying concerns related to education and competitive qualifying examinations, including the New Education Policy and NEET. This is where Udhayanidhi steps in. Despite the many criticisms against him, the youth can readily identify with the jeans and T-shirt-clad DMK scion. His casual and chatty way of electioneering, in contrast to the traditional high-pitched campaign of long-serving DMK stalwarts, including his own father, is also refreshing.

Of course, his swift rise in the party attracts the "dynast" flak from political rivals, but that in itself should not impact the DMK's electoral prospects, unless of course some substantive scam gets linked to Udhayanidhi and the voter is inclined to believe it. "Udhayanidhi is a leader with a constructed image of 'a little prince' and 'the next leader'. He will get the freedom to build a loyalist network but he's unlikely to differ from Stalin in working style or orientation," says Manivannan. Analysts also feel that the deputy CM will take time to cultivate a camp to call his own, and will be careful not to tread on any powerful toes.

An added advantage for the DMK is the inherent constraints faced by both the AIADMK and the BJP. If it was only anti-incumbency against the ruling